



# Language Lessons

Move over books and pens, the Internet is here to teach you new languages...

“I wish life was not so short, languages take such time,” remarked JRR Tolkien, creator of the Hobbits language for *The Lord of The Rings*. Languages may be your passion, or you may want to learn a language to impress your friends, or to make sure taxi drivers in foreign cities don’t rob you blind—the reasons to want to learn a language are not important. What is more pressing is the fact that you may not be able to afford the time or resources to take up a course. So, what do you do?

## One site, many options

If you are not sure about what language you want to learn, visit the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) Web site at <http://www.bbc.co.uk/languages>. The site offers languages from German to Mandarin and even English variants such as Welsh, Irish and Gaelic. It adopts a practical approach for online teaching—using everyday situations, such as taking a taxi, or asking for

directions. The course consists of six stages: from getting your basics right to finding your way around a foreign city and ordering food, you learn everything.

Each stage is complete with situations, grammar tips and vocabulary listings. And you can also use the message boards to

communicate with fellow learners, native speakers, as well as experts. If your language skills have become rusty, you can take the challenge test that the site offers you. All in all, a complete site that also gives you the itinerary for its television programmes on languages. It also has

interesting sections called ‘Oddities in a language’. For example, did you know that the term ‘white rhino’ is a Dutch Afrikaans word?

## One at a time

If you prefer a dedicated Web site for the language of your choice, no sweat! You will find niche sites catering to one particular language. Visit [www.deutsch-lernen.com](http://www.deutsch-lernen.com) to learn German. As with classroom learning, beginners are instructed in grammar, with examples. Advanced learners grapple with



The BBC courses span a myriad of languages